deception tactics against the British in the desert of North Africa amongst various other unrelated things.

On the morning of 9 October, Kaul called a conference that included all officers and JCOs of 9 Punjab and 2 Rajput. Following the same pattern of the lengthy signals to Delhi, the corps commander started by appreciating the impossibility of physically evicting the Chinese from their positions on Thagla or, for that matter, holding on to any gains which the Indians might achieve should they attack. Then he shifted tack, saying that despite the stark facts that indicated that any military offensive would meet with failure, he had no choice since he had been tasked by the Cabinet to make some move by 10 October at the latest. He then proceeded to say that the army commander had told the government that he would evict the Chinese and had set 15 September as the date. This date kept getting postponed giving the impression that the troops of 7 Brigade were stalling and not willing to take on the Chinese. Hence, he, General Kaul, had been appointed to take on this task and lead them into battle. The Cabinet, he added grandly, had let him know that they were willing to lose 20,000 lives if need be, but the Chinese now had to be pushed back.

As a direct assault on Thagla would be impossible, he had decided to do a ‘positional warfare manoeuvre’ and occupy Yumtso-la, to the west of Thagla peak, which at the time was not occupied by the Chinese. He then gave the order to 2 Rajput to cross the Nam Ka Chu on 10 October and go and sit behind the Chinese by occupying Yumtso-la.

Dalvi aptly describes what followed:

‘A variety of astonished gazes greeted Kaul’s announcement. The CO of 2 Rajput, looked at me with consternation clearly visible on his strong face. General Prasad looked as if he had been poleaxed. I was stunned and speechless for a few minutes.’

Rikh turned to Dalvi, seething with anger. There was no way he was going to commit his troops into battle in territory that was uncharted, without reconnaissance, a clear-cut military task and basic fire support. He told Dalvi that the order was a mad one and demanded to know what the brigade and divisional commanders planned to do about it. For Dalvi, it was an impossible situation—there was no way he could contradict the corps commander in the presence of all the JCOs and officers. Yet, he had to do something, since Niranjan Prasad, his boss, was unable to speak at all.